

Iron grip: Into his third full season in the Pro Kabaddi League, Shadloui (in pic, right) is already among the most feared defenders around.

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China. That potentially helped jack up his value at the PKL 10 auction. The ₹2.35 crore that Puneri Paltan doled out for him left even someone with Shadloui's heightened sense of self-worth gobsmacked.

Building a legacy

"We were on the flight back from China, so we couldn't watch the auction. When I found out how much I got, I couldn't believe it. Usually, defenders don't get so much money; it's the raiders who get the most money. This time, all teams have understood that defence is also important. If you have a good defence, then your raiders can do better," he explains.

"I want to make big records in PKL. After 10 years, everything should be in Shadloui's name, and those records should be unbeatable. I want my name to have a legend associated with it, and this is not hard for me to do. It might be hard for others, but not for me," he says.

Kabaddi royalty

It is clear that the Iranian setup sees Shadloui as the future, as evidenced by how he was handed the captain's armband in Busan — a tournament where the squad was packed with young up-and-comers.

However, Shadloui's usual position — the left corner — is one that has traditionally been occupied by a certain Fazel Atrachali (right), Iran's captain, for most of the last decade. Atrachali's success in international and league kabaddi spurred an interest in the sport in his country and among audiences in nations that took to the sport.

The 33-year-old is one of the most experienced players in the ecosystem, with four Asian Games campaigns under his belt from which he has won one gold and three silver medals. He has two Pro Kabaddi titles to his name, one with U Mumba in season two and the other with Patna Pirates in season four.

Atrachali holds the record for



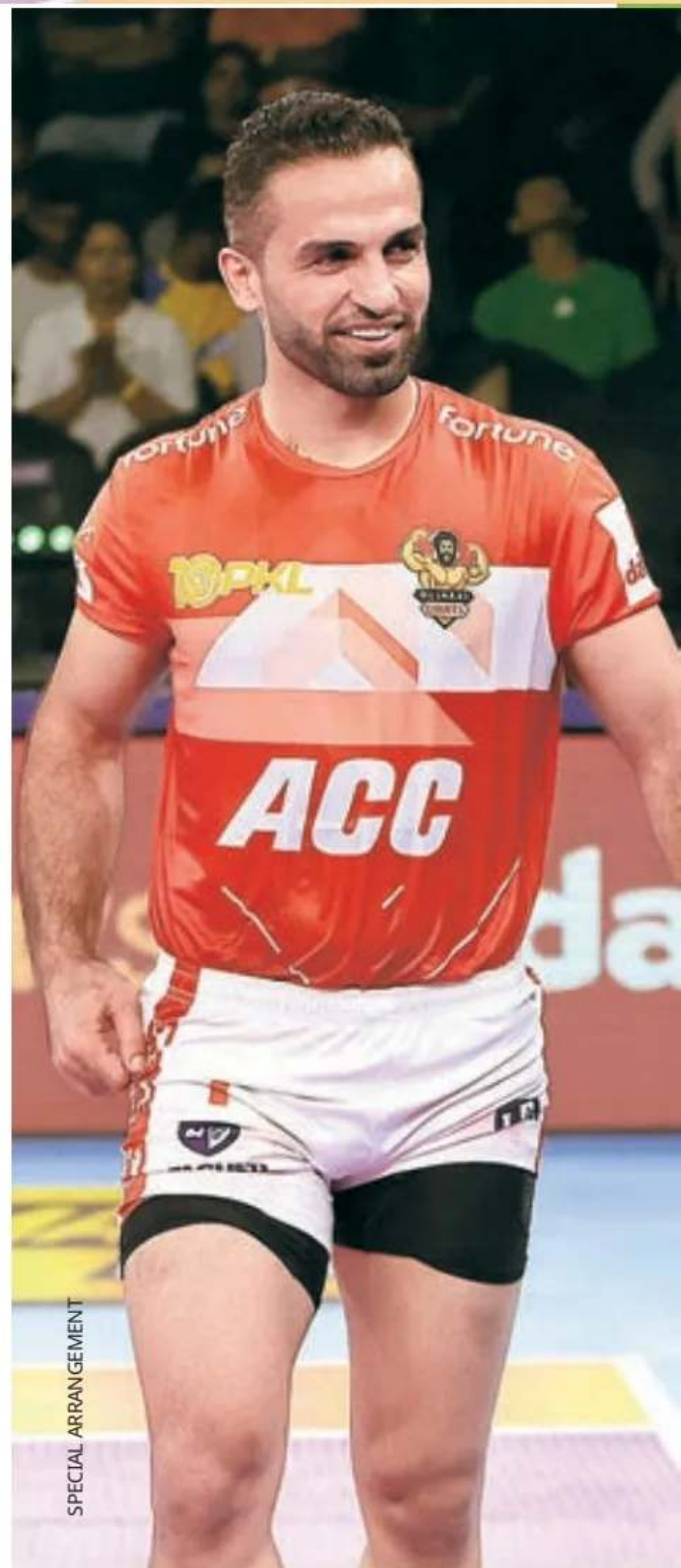
most successful tackles and tackle points (449, as of January 1, 2024). He also has the most wins as captain in PKL history (63 and counting). **He was the first foreign player to draw a ₹1 crore bid in the league and after being the most expensive player in the league for a few seasons in a row, finally ceded that spot to Shadloui,** coming second best this year with Gujarat Giants roping him in for ₹1.38 crore.

He came close to lifting his third PKL title last season with Puneri Paltan, but the side fell short in the final, a loss he deems more painful than the Asian Games defeat to India.

"Last season was very important for me. I wanted to finally lift the trophy as a captain. We were unlucky because in the final, we did not have the services of our main raiders, Aslam Inamdar and Mohit Goyat, who were out injured. At the time, I told myself, 'I tried; I did my best. That's all I can do'. Sometimes, you don't play well, and the team also doesn't. That is really hard. But when you do your best in a losing situation, at least there's something to console yourself with," Atrachali says.

Perils of leadership

There was a time when Atrachali was the obnoxious international



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